



Layered, scalloped bodice

Tightly tailored

Loose pleats at skirt

Strapless silk Jean Dessès, a Greek designer born in Egypt, drew inspiration from his travels. He designed this delicate silk organza dress for Princess Margaret in 1951. A wave-like bodice and the sea-blue colour suggest Dessès was inspired by the ocean.

Stiff silk organza

1951



Ties on shoulder

Snug waist

1953

Influential Fath French fashion designer Jacques Fath designed this stunning silk and wool cocktail dress in 1953. A well-known name in the Paris couture industry, his designs appealed to the international, younger woman.

SHOES



Open-toed, grosgrain shoe



Gold kid peep-toe sandals

Not surprisingly, short cocktail attire placed emphasis on the exposed foot and ankle, requiring an elegant shoe. The high-heeled, generally court, shoe quickly became the icon of the decade and was soon adopted by Hollywood starlets like Jayne Mansfield and Marilyn Monroe, who furthered its sexy image. Gold kid peep-toes, such as those seen here from 1951, were an alternative.



Long, fitted bodice

Froufrou skirt

Froufrou Inspired by both Spanish flamenco dress and ballet costumes of the day, French designer Pierre Balmain created this extravagant cocktail dress in 1957 for the modern young woman. The taffeta and tulle are edged with satin ribbon.

Accordion pleating and rosettes

1957



Boned bodice

Silk ribbon around waist

Overskirt cut away at back to reveal petticoat

Frilled net gives bustle effect

Layered net Created for Lanvin by Spanish-born, but Paris-based, designer Antonio Castillo, this dress has its own built-in petticoat. Black net with white felt spots covers layers of silk taffeta, net, and gauze.



Strapless sheath and wrap

Wraparound bodice and skirt

Bold floral print

Narrow skirt

1958

Sheath dress This 1958 sheath dress with matching wrap in a pink and green floral motif was created by British manufacturer Rodney Dresses. It is an example of an alternative skirt shape acceptable for the cocktail hour.